present, Kosygin attacked US “vandalism and barbarism on an international scale.”[90] When she returned home, following communist pressure, she recalled the Indian consul general in Saigon, who was seen as having defended the US rationale for the bombing.[91] To some observers the announcement of Moscow’s promise of $1 billion in credit for India’s fourth five-year plan appeared to be a reward for her U-turn.[92] Washington meanwhile was seething. The explanation that Gandhi did not criticize the US to the extent that the Soviet Union wanted did nothing to temper the Johnson administration’s adverse reaction.[93]

Indian officials had been aware of Johnson’s sensitivities on Vietnam.[94] Indeed, that was partly why Shastri (and until July 1966, Gandhi too) had been “relatively inactive” on the question.[95] The problem she faced, however, was that just as Johnson said her statements on Vietnam gave his critics ammunition, her critics got ammunition from her silence on the subject.[96] That summer, she had been on the defensive, denying that the quid pro quo for American aid was a Vietnam policy that was more amenable to Washington.[97] By that fall, however, calling for an American bombing halt gave her a way to assert her independence from the US and take on her critics.[98]

The perils of multiple audiences were not lost on Indian policymakers. In Washington, attempting damage control, B. K. Nehru suggested that the communiqué was the result of a “staff snafu.” Gandhi wrote to Johnson, regretting any misunderstanding. She highlighted her subsequent statements to clarify the Indian position. Furthermore, she highlighted the importance of visible nonalignment since that gave her the domestic political credibility to carry on the economic reforms that the US wanted. Finally, she reiterated that India believed that the best way to deal with the situation in Vietnam—and limit Chinese influence there, which was their shared goal—was for the stakeholders to find a solution peacefully.[99]

An unhappy Johnson responded publicly that there was no sign that the other stakeholders were willing to negotiate.[100] Privately, he replied to Gandhi’s contention that Kosygin shared the US and Indian view that a solution should be found at the conference table rather than on the battlefield. He asserted, “The crucial question, of course, remains how this objective can be brought about.” And if Delhi had the answer, it should work with Hanoi and Moscow to get them to yes.[101]